

taxes are attached to liquidating that asset. And I know you just said you need more space, but money problems are love killers. Nothing will end the honeymoon sooner than a leaky roof that has to be paid for with a credit card because the line of credit was used to pay for the wedding. Just continue to rent until a year or two after you have kids. And definitely wait until the honeymoon's *really* over so you have a better idea how each of you handles money.

What kills me the most is when people who can't change a washer on a faucet, let alone a lightbulb, want to take on the care and maintenance of an old, crumbly fixer-upper. Contractors and repair people make a fortune off people like that. If you are chronically useless around the house and don't plan to change, don't buy a house. And certainly, if you're a freelancer, an artist, or you work contract to contract, you've got enough stress in your life. I have a lot of respect for artists and risk-takers, people who are giving their all to make it in their chosen field. Sometimes, a moment of great success, like a big advance on a book or a hit single, will finally yield enough money to allow you to make that healthy down payment on a house. Proceed with caution. You're in a business that is as moody as the markets. A good year doesn't mean you can afford a house. A few good years might. Concentrate on making it big before buying. When that happens, you can buy a house outright—no mortgage, no stress, no problem. Until then, spend that extra money on guitars, getting better headshots, or flying to those auditions in L.A.

With everything we know about home ownership, the pitfalls and potential financial hazards, I'm still baffled that renting carries with it such an unfair stigma. To be a tenant implies that you're transient, unreliable, and unstable. Yet in Switzerland, one of the richest countries in the world, almost two-thirds of the population rents rather than buys. And they enjoy various incentives, such as tax breaks and other deductibles, that the U.S. government offers only to homeowners.

You rent to save on expenses. You rent to avoid the stress of home ownership. Owning a home is a part-time job. Think of your rent money as the cost of all the time you aren't spending raking leaves and shoveling snow or dealing with the raccoons in the attic. You rent